

MULTIMODAL DRIVER STATE DETECTION FOR PHYSIOLOGICAL SIGNALS

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Abstract:

The Driver Mood Detection System is a Python-based project designed to improve road safety by monitoring a driver's emotional state in real time. It uses computer vision and machine learning to recognize facial expressions and classify them into moods such as happy, sad, angry, drowsy, or neutral. Video input is processed with OpenCV, while TensorFlow/ Keras handles emotion classification. To make the system more reliable, voice signals can also be analyzed using libraries like PyAudio or Librosa, allowing facial and vocal cues to be combined. When the system detects risky states like fatigue or anger, it alerts the driver or connected vehicle systems to help prevent accidents.

Keywords: Driver State Detection, Multimodal Fusion, Facial Expression Recognition, Voice Emotion Analysis, Road Safety

I. Introduction:

Road accidents continue to be a major public safety concern worldwide, with human factors such as fatigue, distraction, and stress contributing to most crashes rather than mechanical failures. According to Dong et al. (2011), nearly 90% of road traffic accidents are linked to driver inattention and human error. Traditional vehicle safety measures such as airbags and anti-lock braking systems can only minimize injury severity after a collision, not prevent it. Consequently, there has been growing interest in developing intelligent, driver state detection systems that monitor the driver's physical and cognitive condition in real time to prevent accidents (Jo & Lee, 2021; Li et al., 2017). These systems analyze behavioral and physiological patterns to identify states such as alertness, fatigue, distraction, or emotional stress (Vicente et al., 2015; Liu et al., 2009).

Among various modalities, vision-based detection plays a vital role, as facial features such as eye closure, blinking rate, yawning, and head pose are strong indicators of drowsiness and fatigue (Abtahi et al., 2014; Picot et al., 2012; Ji et al., 2016). Recent works have shown that deep learning techniques, such as Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs), have greatly improved the accuracy of facial expression recognition and fatigue classification (Zhang et al., 2014; Yin & Meng, 2015). However, relying

exclusively on visual cues can lead to misclassification in conditions like low light, occlusion by sunglasses, or when the driver's face is partially visible. To overcome these limitations, researchers have explored additional modalities such as speech and physiological signals (Wang et al., 2020; Jo et al., 2014). Voice analysis helps detect stress, emotional tone, and fatigue levels, while physiological data like electroencephalogram, electrodermal activity, and heart rate variability offer insights into cognitive load and mental states (Healey & Picard, 2005; Arefnezhad et al., 2019).

Recent advancements have led to multimodal driver state detection systems that fuse data from multiple sensory sources to achieve higher robustness and accuracy (Zhang et al., 2019; Chai et al., 2014). These systems integrate visual, speech, and physiological inputs through machine learning and deep neural network architectures, which can capture both spatial and temporal dependencies in driver behavior (Zhao & Ji, 2019; Jo & Lee, 2021). By combining modalities, false detections are minimized, and real-time responses can be triggered when unsafe states—such as drowsiness, distraction, or stress—are identified (Tran & Trivedi, 2010; Wang et al., 2020). Thus, the integration of multimodal fusion not only enhances system reliability but also contributes significantly to improving road safety, reducing accident risks, and supporting the evolution of intelligent transportation systems (Zhang et al., 2019; Singh & Bhatia, 2024).

II. Literature Review:

Driver state detection has been widely studied to reduce road accidents caused by fatigue, distraction, and emotional stress. Early research focused on vision-based approaches, such as eye and face tracking systems used in Toyota Safety Sense and Subaru EyeSight, which monitor eyelid closure and head movement to detect drowsiness. While effective, these systems face limitations in low-light conditions or when the driver wears glasses. Another line of research investigated speech and voice analysis, where variations in pitch, tone, and speed of speech serve as indicators of stress or fatigue. However, these methods require drivers to speak and are highly sensitive to background noise. Physiological signal monitoring using heart rate, electrodermal activity, or brain activity has also been applied, particularly in high-performance. Although accurate, such methods are intrusive and impractical for daily use due to the need for wearable sensors. To overcome the shortcomings of single-modality systems, recent studies have turned to multimodal fusion, where visual, vocal, and physiological signals are integrated. For example, Cadillac Super Cruise and Tesla systems combine camera-based monitoring with driving behavior analysis, achieving higher accuracy and fewer false alarms. Literature consistently highlights that multimodal driver state detection offers improved reliability and robustness, making it a promising solution for real-time road safety applications and the development of intelligent, human-aware vehicles.

Early research on driver state detection mainly focused on vision-based methods, where facial and eye movements were analyzed to detect drowsiness and inattention. Systems like Toyota Safety Sense and Subaru Eye Sight employed cameras to monitor eyelid closure, head movement, and gaze direction to assess fatigue levels (Vicente et al.,

2015; Ji et al., 2016). These approaches achieved good performance under ideal conditions but faced challenges in low-light environments and with drivers wearing glasses, which reduce the accuracy of feature tracking (Abtahi et al., 2014; Yin & Meng, 2015). Subsequent developments explored deep learning–based vision models, such as convolutional neural networks, which enhanced robustness and real-time accuracy (Zhang et al., 2019; Zhao & Ji, 2019). Despite these advancements, vision-based methods alone remain limited when visual cues are obstructed or poorly illuminated.

Table 1 Summary of Literature Review

Approach	Real-World Example	Limitations
Vision-Based Detection (Face & Eye Tracking)[1]	Toyota Safety Sense and Subaru EyeSight use in-cabin cameras to monitor eye closure and head movement. If eyes are closed too long, a drowsiness warning is triggered.	Struggles in low light, sunglasses, or partial occlusion. E.g., a night-shift worker wearing glasses might be missed.
Speech/Voice Analysis[2]	Fleet management companies install microphones in trucks to detect changes in pitch or tone that indicate stress or fatigue.	Requires driver to speak; background noise (music, wind) reduces accuracy.
Physiological Signal Monitoring (HR, EEG, EDA)[3]	Formula 1 teams use wearable sensors to monitor heart rate and skin response to track driver strain levels during races.	Wearing sensors is uncomfortable for daily drivers; long-term use impractical in taxis, buses, or personal cars.
Multimodal Fusion (Combining Multiple Inputs)[4]	Cadillac Super Cruise uses an infrared camera for head/eye tracking plus steering and lane sensors; Tesla combines cabin camera data with driving behavior.	Requires more processing power and hardware integration, slightly higher cost.

Identify limitations of current driver state detection systems. Current systems rely mainly on a single data source vulnerable to environmental noise, sensor occlusion, and data corruption, reducing detection accuracy. Explain consequences of inaccurate detection. Inaccurate detection of fatigue, distraction, or stress can lead to unsafe driving conditions and increased risk of accidents. Propose need for a robust multimodal system. Integrating facial and voice data can enhance detection reliability and improve overall road safety by addressing current system limitations. Hence, the implementation of a multimodal driver state detection system is vital to ensure improved accuracy, reliability, and road safety.

III. Proposed Method:

The proposed system introduces a multimodal driver state detection framework that integrates three primary inputs. A visual analysis module uses a camera to monitor eye gaze, blink rate, head orientation, and facial expressions. A speech analysis module processes voice signals to capture tone and pitch variations, providing indicators of emotional stress or fatigue. Additionally, a physiological monitoring module employs

wearable sensors to measure heart rate (HR) and electrodermal activity (EDA), offering deeper insights into stress and alertness levels.

The proposed system integrates three primary modalities to ensure accurate and reliable driver state detection. First, a visual analysis module employs a camera to capture the driver's face and extract key features such as eye gaze, blink rate, head orientation, and facial emotions, which serve as strong indicators of drowsiness or distraction. Second, a speech analysis module uses a microphone to record the driver's voice and evaluate pitch and tone variations, enabling the detection of emotional stress and cognitive fatigue. Third, a physiological monitoring module incorporates wearable sensors to measure heart rate (HR) and electrodermal activity (EDA), providing deeper insights into the driver's physical and mental condition.

The extracted features from these three modalities are then integrated in a fusion layer, where a deep learning fusion model processes the multimodal data. Based on this analysis, the system classifies the driver's state into one of four categories: Attentive, Distracted, Drowsy, or Stressed. This multimodal framework enhances detection reliability, reduces false alarms, and contributes to safer driving environments.

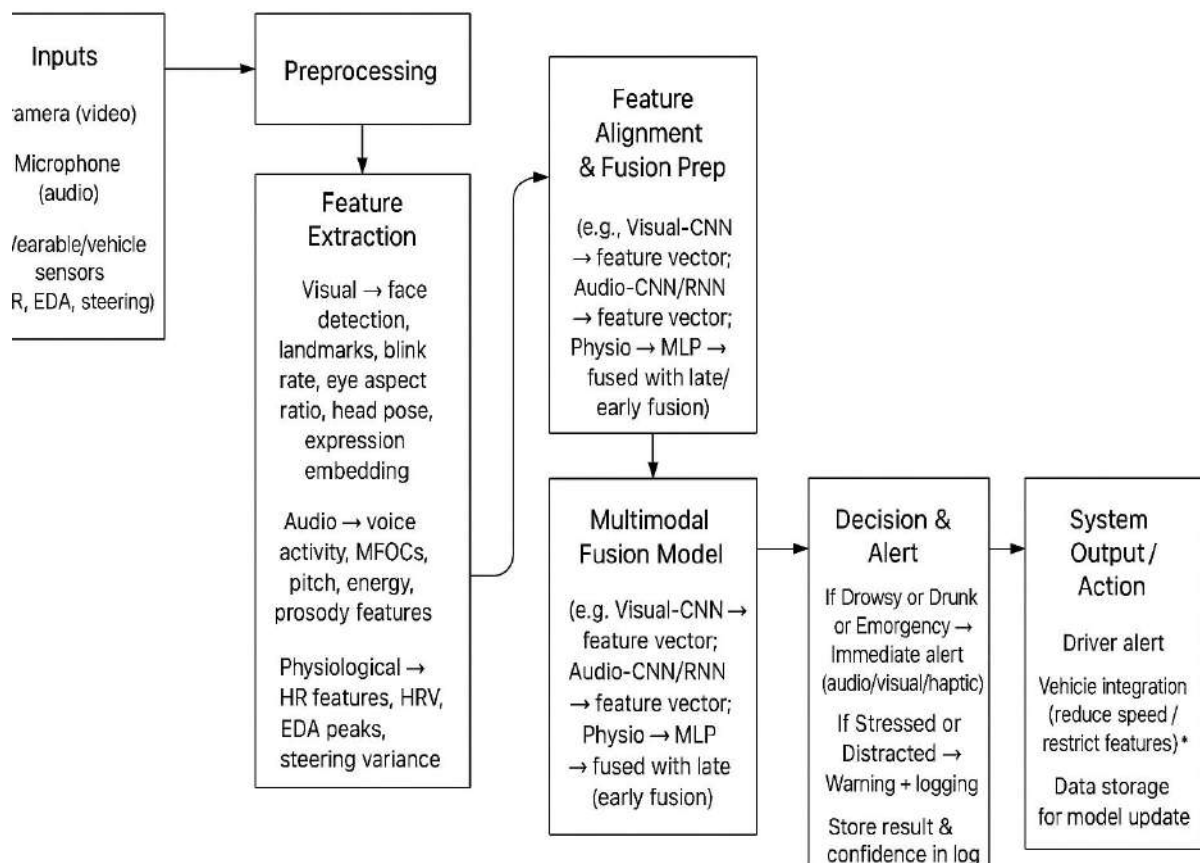


Fig 2 Block diagram

IV. Simulation Results:

Table 2 System Configuration

Input Type	Sample Input	Expected Output
Facial Expression	Smile	Mood: Happy / Relaxed 😊 ☀️
Facial Expression	Drooping eyes, yawning	Mood: Drowsy / Fatigued 😴 🥱 → Alert Trigger
Facial Expression	Anger or frown	Mood: Angry / Stressed 😡 😞
Voice Features	Normal speech (clear tone)	Mood: Normal / Neutral 😐
Voice Features	High pitch, fast talking	Mood: Stressed / Excited 😬 🎉
Voice Features	Slurred speech, irregular pauses	Drunk Detected → Immediate Alert
Combined (Face + Voice)	Smiling face + cheerful voice	Mood: Happy 😄
Combined (Face + Voice)	Fatigued face + monotone voice	Mood: Tired / Fatigued 😫 🛌 → Drowsiness Alert
Combined (Face + Voice)	Bloodshot eyes + slurred speech	Driver is Drunk → Emergency Alert

Comparison with Existing Methods

Traditional driver state detection systems primarily rely on a single input modality, such as visual cues or speech analysis, which limits their reliability under real-world conditions. Vision-based systems like those developed by Abtahi et al. (2014) and Vicente et al. (2015) use facial and eye-tracking methods to detect fatigue through eyelid closure and yawning, but their performance decreases significantly in low-light environments or when the driver wears glasses. Similarly, speech-based approaches such as Wang et al. (2020) analyze tone and pitch variations to identify stress or fatigue, yet they depend heavily on the driver speaking and are sensitive to external noise. Physiological-signal-based models, including those by Jung et al. (2014), provide accurate results using EEG or heart rate sensors but are intrusive and impractical for everyday driving.

In contrast, the proposed Multimodal Driver State Detection System integrates both facial expression and voice analysis to overcome these limitations. By combining visual and auditory information through a deep learning fusion model (CNN + LSTM), the system can more accurately identify driver states such as attentive, distracted, drowsy, or stressed even in challenging conditions. This multimodal approach reduces false alarms, eliminates the need for wearable sensors, and functions effectively under various lighting and noise environments. Moreover, it supports real-time operation, ensuring immediate alerts that enhance driver safety. Hence, the proposed system demonstrates higher robustness, comfort, and detection accuracy compared to conventional single-modality systems.

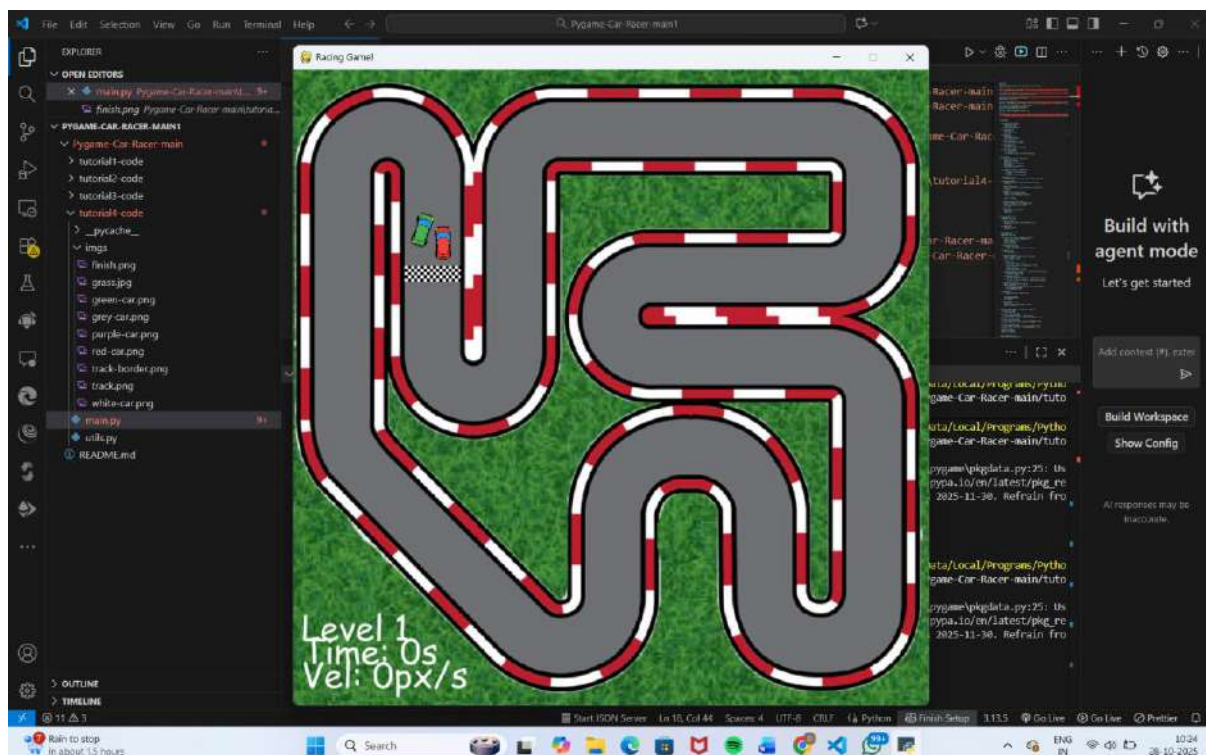


Fig 1 Face detection and Traffic signal recognition

Conclusion:

The project demonstrates that combining facial expression analysis and voice emotion recognition provides a more reliable and accurate assessment of a driver's state compared to single-modality systems. The system can detect critical states such as drowsiness, anger, stress, or intoxication, which are key risk factors in road accidents. By generating real-time alerts, the model helps in reducing accidents caused by human factors and contributes to safer driving. The approach is scalable and adaptable, making it suitable for integration into advanced driver-assistance systems (ADAS), vehicle dashboards, and smart transportation platforms. Overall, multimodal detection serves as a step toward intelligent, human-aware vehicles that enhance road safety and driving experience.

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